

FAMILY TOGETHERNESS WEEK OF PRAYER
SEPTEMBER 4 - 10, 2022

 Adventist[®]
Family Ministries



BY
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TEACHING *our children to* WORSHIP AND LOVE GOD

SCRIPTURE TEXT:

**“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart,
with all your soul, and with all your strength.”**

Deuteronomy 6: 5 (NKJV)

It is a common practice on college campuses today to have professors participate in what is known as the “Last Lecture” talks. In these talks professors are asked to think deeply about what matters to them and to express these thoughts in a hypothetical final instruction or guidance for the audience. The audience is left to ponder their own ways of imparting wisdom if they knew they only had this final chance. Normally, professors are quite healthy while delivering a speech suggesting their demise is imminent.

Dr. Randy Pausch, however, was *not* healthy when he delivered his “Last Lecture.” The 46-year-old professor of computer science at Carnegie Mellon University in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania (in the United States) had been diagnosed with pancreatic cancer and given only a few months to live. This father of three used his final lecture to leave a legacy for his own children, his students and to the world, as his lecture became a best-selling book.

One thing that stands out in his book is his love for his family and for humankind. He encourages us to be patient with others, saying: “wait long enough, and people will surprise you and impress you.”

He showed pictures of his childhood bedroom wall decorated with mathematical equations he had drawn on the walls. He urges parents to allow their children to draw, paint and write on their bedroom walls as a favor to him, just as his mom had allowed him to do. He states that his mom believed in him and was patient and supportive in helping him fulfill his dreams. He once said, “Like Moses, I get to see the Promised Land, but I don’t get to step foot in it.”

It’s interesting that in this academic lecture, Dr. Pausch mentions the Prophet Moses. Indeed, Moses, too, had a lot to say to his ‘students’, his children, his people, the children of Israel, prior to his last climb up to Mount Nebo. Moses’ last lecture found in Deuteronomy 6:4-9, commonly known as the *Shema*, first stresses to the children of Israel that there is only one true God and reminds them of the commandment to “love the Lord your God with all your heart, soul and might.” The *Shema* admonishes parents to “diligently teach” their children to love God, every opportunity they get, ‘in the morning, during the day, and at night.’ It is a declaration of faith, a pledge of allegiance to Jehovah—the one true God.

This final message of Moses can be a companion to the final lecture of the Old Testament found in the book of Malachi 4:5,6, “Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes. And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children and the hearts of the children to their fathers, lest I come and strike the land with a decree of utter destruction.” (ESV) These are the final words of the Old Testament.

The Elijah Message found in this passage of scripture in Malachi says there will be turning of hearts before “the great and awesome day of the Lord comes.” Elijah’s message was a bold message to the people and families of his day, and still very much needed for our families of today. It is a reminder of the heart-turning work that God is going to do before the second coming of Jesus Christ. In the book of Malachi, the people had not only abandoned their covenant with God, but they had also abandoned their family covenants. Hence, the book of Malachi looks back to the times of Elijah the prophet who confronted the altars of Baal worship and rebuilds the altar of Jehovah, the one true God¹. Elijah had to restore the broken altars and teach the people how to worship again, restore their memory of the last lecture of Moses, where they were reminded of the commandment to love the one true God.

The most miraculous part of this story is the extravagant love of God for His people. When the fire fell, it consumed only the burnt offering but not the people. Despite the sinfulness of the people, God

¹For further study: Read 1 Kings 17, 18. Also Ellen G. White, Prophets and Kings, Youngberg, John (2021) Where Are the Elijahs?



does not destroy them but gives them an opportunity to repent and turn their hearts to Him and to their children and others. When God restores there must always be a turning of hearts.

During this ***Family Togetherness Week of Prayer***, our desire is for families to build or rebuild the altar of family worship in their homes. Family worship gives every family an opportunity to daily rebuild the altar of God. The Elijah Message is about heart-turning, not just obedience, and it's the same with family worship. It is not about forcing children and families to have family worship; it is a message that turns the hearts of the parents to their children and children to their parents. It is about the relationship of family members to each other and to God. Family worship is an opportunity for family members to reflect the warmth of God's love, forgiveness, and acceptance.

How do we rebuild altars in 2022? What are the altars of Baal in our homes today that need to be destroyed so that God's altar can be rebuilt? How can we teach our children and families to worship God and rebuild the family altar as Elijah rebuilt the altar in his day? In our homes today, there is a deep yearning for connection. Many family relationships have been broken and need to be restored. We need modern-day Elijahs in homes that desperately need hope, healing, and heart-turning. We need to restore our relationship with the one true God, Jehovah, the only one who can bring true peace, hope, and healing to our hearts and homes.

During this week of prayer, we endeavor to inspire new habits of positive and healthy communication in your home; heart-turning behaviors that are grounded in grace and the fruit of the spirit. When we rebuild the family altar daily, we make a statement that we are putting Jesus Christ at the center of our lives and in our homes. We pray this new or restored habit of family worship will become a regular habit that will bond our families closer together, deepen our faith in God, help us to share the good news of the gospel with others, and better prepare us for the soon coming of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ.

Maranatha!



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